



Indian restaurants in Japan, I think 1,200 in Tokyo alone. That means the familiarity has increased.

SK: Do you think India could have done anything else to make sure that Hitachi is more excited?

BK: It's worked differently in different industries. In some cases, where we see that India can take one of the top three leadership positions, the push is seen very differently and the coming together of Japanese technology is encouraged. In still others, because we are also a noisy democracy, and I say this with a lot of respect for all our processes, but sometimes when it was only a price bid, Japanese companies would be outsmarted 35% on an average. It's only later when there was a life cycle cost that they started finding favour.

Scan here for the full video of the interview

| **THE BT INTERVIEW** |



SK: How does Hitachi look at sustainability?

BK: Japan was the first to raise the bar without making any noise on environment and sustainability when everything was understood as one. And the Japanese financial institutions, government finance, were always linked to this. Today's conundrum is that the benchmarks are not defined. The hesitation of capacity building vis-à-vis the experimentation that is required makes you focus either on foundational technologies, which will be a new source right from the input all the way to the delivery, or on transitional technologies where the existing assets are getting smarter and greener. The focus in Japan was always on existing assets, because then the transition is better understood. Today, including in artificial intelligence, you have humongous responsibility, and we are talking everywhere about data free flow with trust. This is transformative. It's bigger than splitting the atom, or the invention of internet.

SZ: What is your company doing about AI in India?

BK: Like any major transformational change, AI is a reality. It has been unleashed, and you can't stop it, you must ride it. And you must embrace it with that earnestness and commitment, as a policy, as a business, as an end user. However, at some point, there must be responsibility to protect against what mustn't happen. That's a very difficult and big challenge today.

For instance, 500 million people have Ayushman Bharat IDs in India. And there is a huge demand and supply gap between healthcare facilities and the entitlement of healthcare. Do you really get AI in clinical treatment? There is this genuine challenge. We have a global centre for AI in Bengaluru, and we are doing solutions from biodiversity to energy, rail, education, agriculture, all the way to the metaverse. It predicted when people should move out during the Californian fires, because of wind direction, etc. And then there is more mundane stuff for day-to-day efficiencies in business models. But you must think how much of it, and at what speed, should I adopt so that the whole system is in consonance.

But the speed with which AI can deliver human completeness, physical, social or psychological, as an experience, has a limitless potential. It cannot be matched by anything else. Ultimately, in a connected society, a business strategy is evergreen. Technologies will come and go. **BT**

@szarabi